Managing startup apps and background processes

Article KB0010034 | Owner: Desktop Support | Subcategory: Laptop slow / freezing | Applies to: Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840 running Windows 11 23H2/24H2, MacBook Pro/Air on macOS 14/15

Summary

This article provides guidance for Acme Global employees and Desktop Support agents on diagnosing and resolving slow performance, frequent hangs, and high CPU usage on company laptops by reviewing and managing startup applications, background processes, and temporary files.

Symptoms

- Laptop feels very slow during everyday tasks
- System hangs or freezes for several seconds, especially during Teams calls
- High CPU usage shown in Task Manager (often >80%)
- Fan runs constantly and laptop gets warm
- Boot time exceeds two minutes

Common causes

- Too many programs configured to launch at startup
- Background services or apps consuming excessive CPU/RAM
- Accumulation of temporary files and cache reducing disk performance
- Pending Windows updates that require a restart after extended uptime
- Insufficient memory (less than 8?GB) for the current workload
- Presence of unwanted software or malware

Preliminary Checks

Before making changes, verify the basic health of the device. Open Task Manager (Ctrl+Shift+Esc) and note the CPU, memory, and disk usage percentages. Check the Startup tab to see which programs are set to run at login and their impact rating. Ensure there is at least 15?GB of free space on the system drive, as low disk space can exacerbate slowdowns. Finally, look at Windows Update settings to see if any feature or quality updates are pending a restart.

Self-Help: Managing Startup Apps and Background Processes

Follow these steps to reduce the number of programs that start automatically and to clean up temporary files. The procedure works on Windows 11 laptops; macOS users can follow the equivalent steps outlined after the Windows instructions.

1. Open Task Manager by pressing Ctrl+Shift+Esc, then select the Startup tab.
2. Sort the list by Startup impact. Disable any item marked "High" that you do not recognize or that is not essential for your work (right-click -> Disable).
3. Open Settings -> Apps -> Startup and toggle off additional non-essential apps that appear here.
4. If you prefer using the classic tool, press Win+R, type msconfig and hit Enter. In the Services tab, check "Hide all Microsoft services", then disable any remaining third-party services that are not required.
5. To clear temporary files, open Settings -> System -> Storage -> Temporary files and select items such as Downloads, Recycle Bin, and Temporary Internet Files, then click Remove files. Alternatively, run Disk Cleanup (cleanmgr.exe) and choose system files.
6. Restart the laptop. After logging back in, open Task Manager again and verify that CPU usage is lower and that the startup impact list shows fewer high-impact items. If performance is still unsatisfactory, proceed to the service-desk procedure.

Service Desk Agent Procedure

When a user reports slow performance after attempting self-help, the agent should perform a deeper diagnostic, verify configurations, and apply remediation steps that require elevated privileges or remote tools.

1. Confirm the user's device model, OS version, and current uptime via Intune or the Company Portal.
2. Initiate a remote assistance session (Teams or Remote Help) and open Task Manager to capture a screenshot of

CPU, memory, and disk usage.
3. Review the startup list using both Task Manager and the Autoruns utility (downloadable from the internal software repository) to identify any hidden or scheduled tasks.
4. Check pending Windows Update status; if updates have been pending for more than three days, schedule a restart and monitor if performance improves post-reboot.
5. Run the built-in Windows Disk Cleanup utility with the option to clean system files, and then execute the Storage Sense cleanup script via Intune if needed.
6. If RAM utilization remains above 85?% after closing non-essential apps, collect a memory usage report and consider opening a hardware ticket for a RAM upgrade to 16?GB per the standard hardware refresh policy.

Verification and Follow-up

After applying the changes, it is important to confirm that the issue is resolved before closing the ticket. Ask the user to monitor performance for at least 30?minutes, focusing on the scenarios that originally caused the slowdown (e.g., joining a Teams call, opening large files). Request a follow-up screenshot of Task Manager showing acceptable CPU usage (<40?%) and normal disk activity. If the user reports continued slowness, gather the collected logs and escalate according to the escalation guidelines below.

When to escalate

If performance does not improve after completing the self-help and service-desk steps, or if the user reports recurring freezes, escalate to the Desktop Support senior team. Include the following details in the escalation ticket: device serial number, OS build, uptime, screenshots of Task Manager (processes, startup, performance), Autoruns output, Disk Cleanup log, and any error messages from the Event Viewer (look for application hangs or driver failures). Also note whether the issue occurs on ACME-Corp Wi-Fi, ACME-Guest, or while connected to the VPN, as this can help isolate network-related contributors.

Keywords: slow laptop, high CPU, startup apps, background processes, freezing, Task Manager, Disk Cleanup, storage sense, msconfig, Autoruns, RAM upgrade, Intune